System Overview

Spotify is a free-to-download app on the Google and Apple Play stores and is available for use on PC and TV. It is an audio streaming platform that allows users to listen to music, podcasts, and audiobooks. Users can pay for a premium subscription of various tiers to unlock extra features such as downloading music, offline listening, and other perks unavailable for those with a free plan.

Evaluation Methods

This heuristic evaluation was conducted using [Jakob Nielsen's 10 Usability Heuristics for User Interface Design].

On January 20th, 2025, the evaluator inspected the entirety of version 9.0.10.415 of the Spotify mobile app viewed with an Android phone. The evaluator identified **3** usability problems. Results from this inspection are detailed below, including images. A 0-4 rating scale was used to rate the severity of each usability problem.

0 = I disagree that this is a usability problem at all
1 = Cosmetic problem only: need not be fixed unless extra time is available
2 = Minor usability problem: fixing this should be given low priority
3 = Major usability problem: important to fix, so should be given high priority
4 = Usability catastrophe: imperative to fix this before the product can be released

The usability problems are grouped by 10 main categories:

1. Visibility of system status
2. Match between the system and the real world
3. User control and freedom
4. **Consistency and standards**
5. Error prevention
6. Help users recognize, diagnose, and recover from errors
7. Recognition rather than recall
8. Flexibility and efficiency of use
9. **Aesthetic and minimalist design**
10. **Help and documentation**

Heuristic Evaluation Results

1. Visibility of System Status

No problems were detected.

2. Match Between System and The Real World

No problems were detected.

3. User Control and Freedom

No problems were detected.

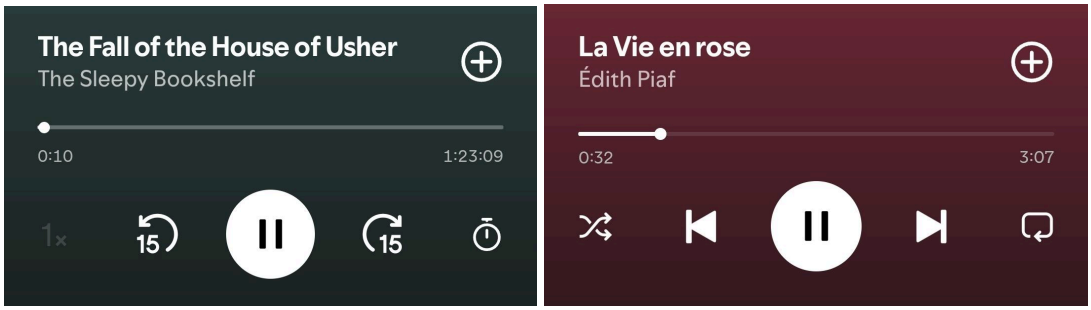
4. Consistency and Standards

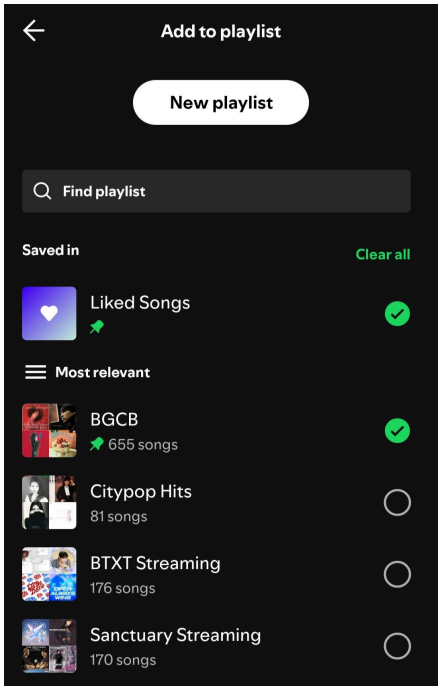
Tools Have Multiple Outputs

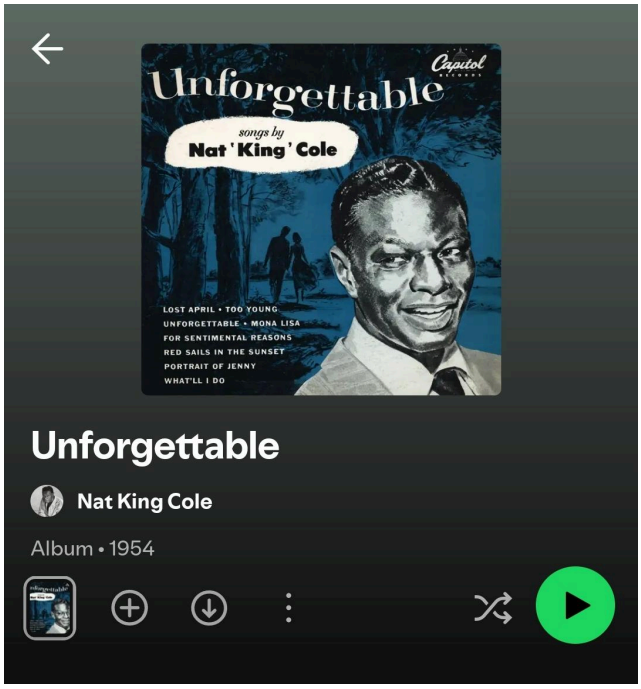
Problem description: When listening to music, the user has the ability to skip to the next song using the arrow to the right of the play/pause button. The user can click on the arrow on the left to replay the current song or to go to the previous song. Sometimes, it is necessary to double-click to go back to the previous song as it will first replay the current song. While the podcast and audiobook interface is similar, the arrows on the sides of the play/pause button are different, as they rewind and fast forward by 15 seconds. This inconsistency may not be the most confusing, but it can be annoying if you want to skip to the next episode of a podcast or want to go forward a few seconds in a song because the features aren't available for both.

Another problem would be the "add" button. Before it was a plus sign, it was a heart that would add the song to the user's "Liked Songs." Now, it has multiple uses. If on a song, clicking the plus sign adds it to the "Liked Songs" playlist. Clicking it on an album adds it to the library, so if the user wants to add the album to their playlist, they have to click on the three dots instead. For a podcast / audiobook, it brings up a menu where you can either add it to an "Episodes" playlist or add it to your library. After adding, if the user clicks on the plus sign again, a menu pops up that shows where the item is in playlists so the user can then choose to remove or add it.

Example, including screenshots/images: Image One: Podcast Interface | Image Two: Song Interface | Image Three: Add to Playlist Pop-up | Image Four: Album Interface







Severity: 3. This is a major usability issue because it confuses new and old users.

Requirements for improvement: The user interaction should be Like → Add *or* LIke → Pop-up → Add for all content on the app instead of some of the content requiring a path of the former while other content requires the latter. Also, give the user the option to fully skip or only fast forward / rewind for all content on the app, not just having one or the other for certain content. It could be beneficial to see all the tools the app utilizes, look at what each does, and then minimize the amount of different outputs they have by combining or removing tedious features. For example, instead of using the plus sign to add an album to the library, the output should play the album in a chosen playlist and the choice to add to the library can be moved to the menu under three dots.

5. Error Prevention

No problems were detected.

6. Help Users Recognize, Diagnose, and Recover From Errors

No problems were detected.

7. Recognition Rather than Recall

No problems were detected.

8. Flexibility and Efficiency of Use

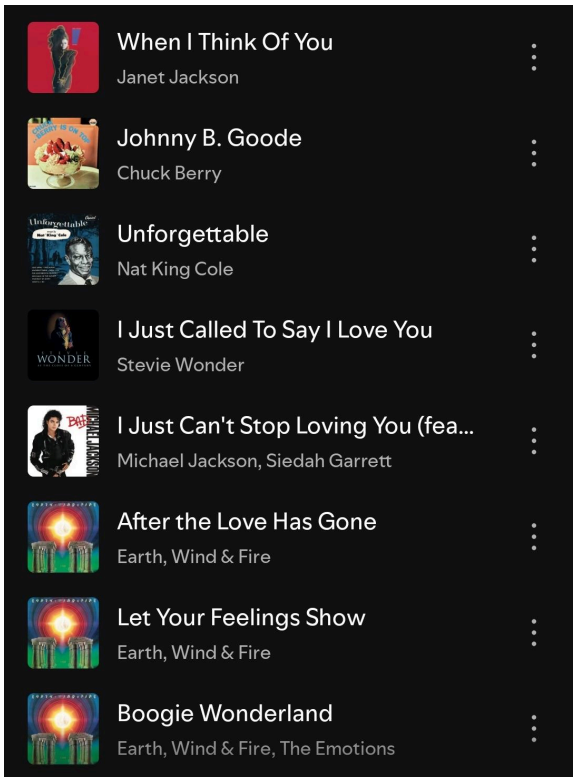
No problems were detected.

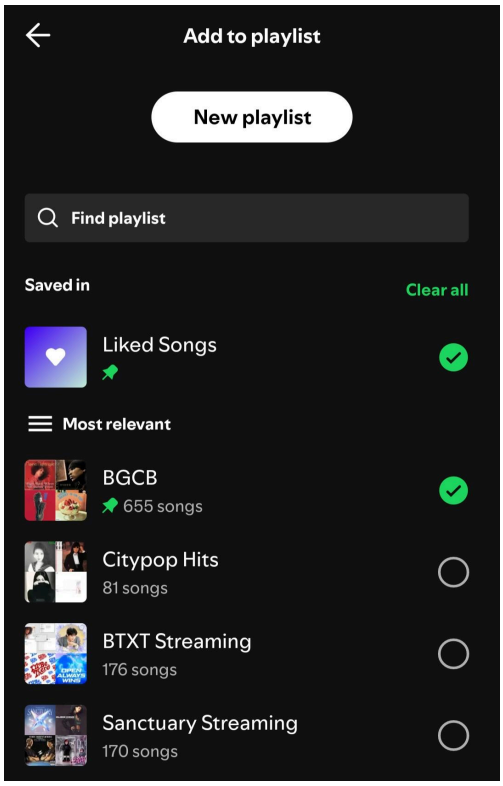
9. Aesthetic and Minimalist Design

Minimalism Hinders Ease of Use

Problem description: The add button is important, but similar to when viewing an album, you have to click on the three dots of songs individually when viewing a playlist because Spotify no longer has the add button next to the song when you view it in a playlist. This is inconvenient when you want to add multiple songs to a playlist because instead of simply clicking on the “add” button, you must click on the three dots, click on “add to liked songs” or “add to playlist” in the pop-up, and if you choose the latter, you are directed to another screen in order to add it to your chosen playlist.

Example, including screenshots/images: A list of songs within a playlist and the menu that pops up when you click on the three dots.





Severity: 3. This is a major usability issue because not only does it make adding music to a playlist more difficult, it can also cause the user to accidentally click on, and play, the song they were trying to add which will interrupt their current listening experience. The menu is helpful for when the user wants to add a song to multiple playlists at the same time, but it is unhelpful if they want to add multiple songs at the same time.

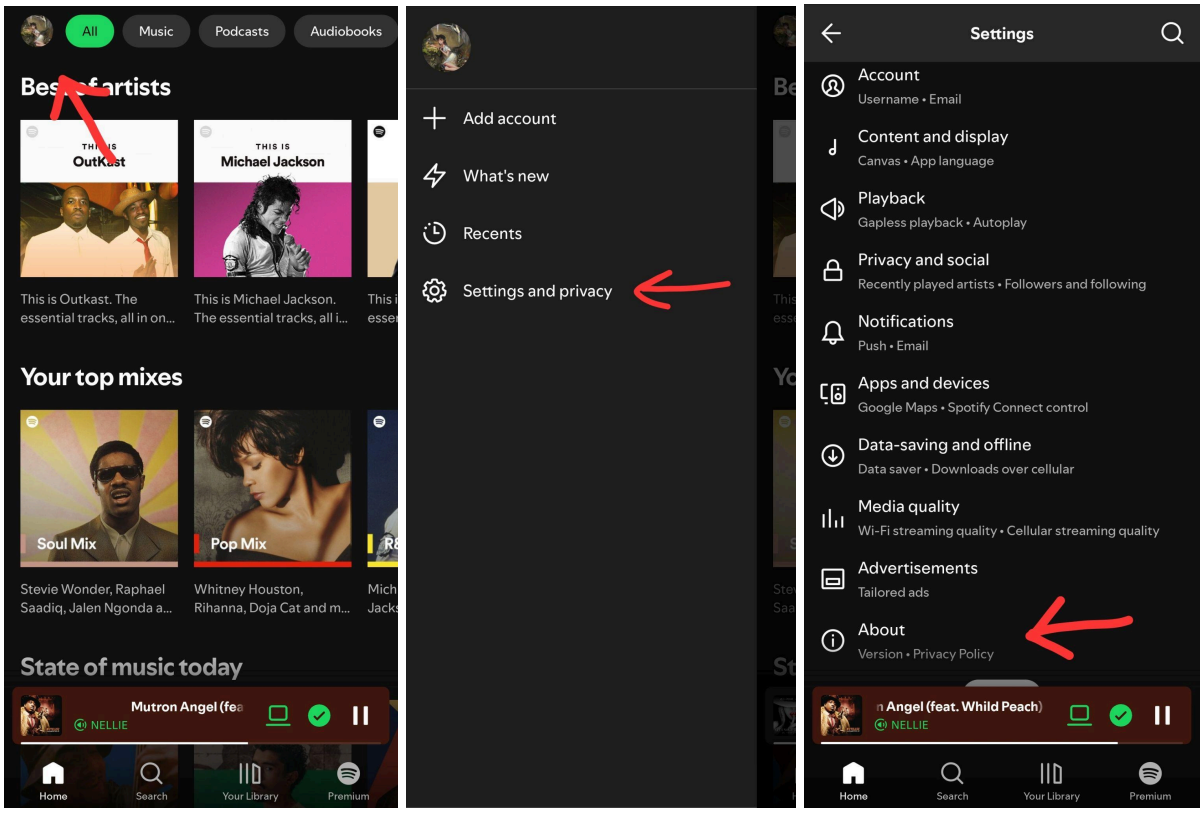
Requirements for improvement: The PC version allows the user to left-click on a song, then shift-click other songs to select them at the same time. When the user right-clicks, they get a pop-up where they can add all of the selected songs to their desired playlist. If properly executed, this would improve the process on mobile devices. Currently, if you click and hold a song, it brings up the same pop-up as the three dots. Instead, the action could allow the user to select multiple songs at a time.

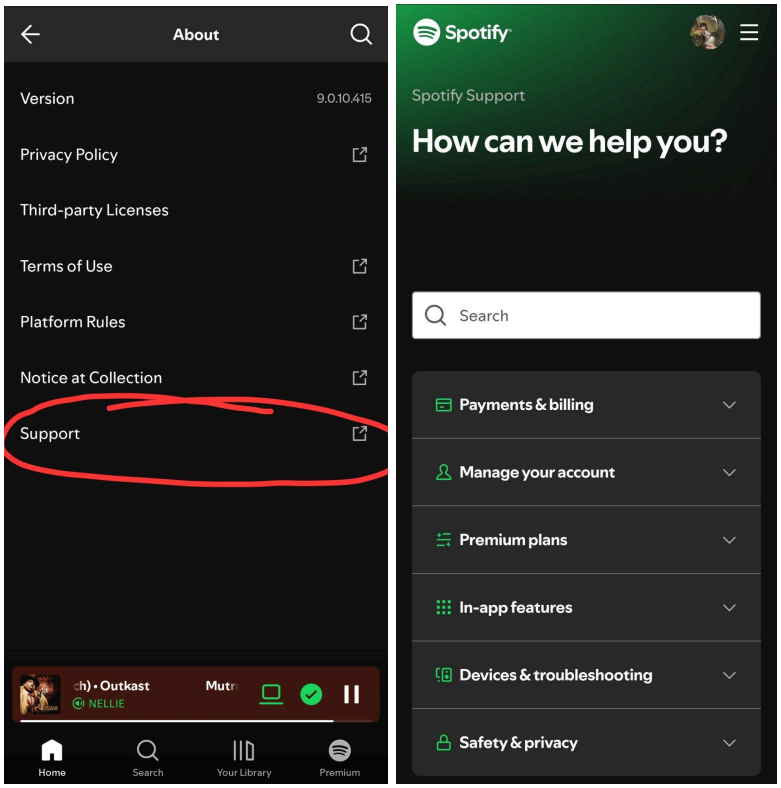
10. Help and Documentation

Contacting Support is Hidden

Problem description: The user has to jump through hoops to contact support or find an FAQ page. After going through multiple menus, the user is then redirected to a browser instead of being able to stay in the app.

Example, including screenshots/images: The user must jump through multiple hoops to reach a support page outside of the app, and the path to get there is hidden and unintuitive.





Severity: 4. This is a usability catastrophe because getting support should not be tedious, and the difficulty can seem deceitful. There are multiple signposts to convince the user to buy premium, but nothing if the user needs support.

Requirements for improvement: The support page should be less hidden and a FAQ screen should be readily available for the user. Tools to reach them could easily be placed right in settings or below it in the pop-up menu.

Recommendations for Improvement

This study identifies **1 severe, urgent** issue that should be addressed to eliminate problems that have the potential to threaten the company's relationship with the user.

- 10. Help and Documentation: Contacting Support is Hidden (Subscription plans are given higher priority).

This study identifies **2** problems that are considered **major** usability problems that are important to fix and are of high priority.

- 4. Consistency and Standards: Tools Have Multiple Outputs
- 9. Aesthetic and Minimalism: Minimalism Hinders Ease of Use

When it comes to improvement, accessibility is most important. Accessing support should be as easy as accessing subscription plans and aesthetics should not get in the way of the user's experience. While making sure the user isn't overwhelmed is necessary, tools should have clear and consistent outputs that apply to all the content within the app. A tool that redirects to B should not redirect to C when in a different area of the app.